

Later in life, we became much less interested in money. We thought about it less. We knew we had plenty. We turned our attentions from our standard of living, measured in dollars, to the quality of our lives, which we couldn't measure at all.

That's the advantage of F-U money.

When you don't have F-U money, you tend to be interested in politics. You want the government to pay for your pills, your children's education, and your retirement. You figure it's written somewhere in the "social contract." Or even in the constitution. You will be a good citizen, vote, and pay your taxes. The government will look out for you. If you have no independent means of your own, the bargain is almost irresistible.

That's the trouble with money that comes from government subsidies, bailouts, regulations, and sweetheart contracts. It's not really F-U money. You depend on the feds. You can't say "F-U" to the feds. They can say it to you. They're the ones with the power. So you tend to keep a keen interest in politics, buying politicians if you're able, sucking up to them if you're not.

F-U money is liberating. It doesn't really matter how much it is, just as long as it is enough so you can make your own decisions free from the pressures of politics, desperation, or envy. F-U allows you think clearly. It permits you to do what you want, too. It makes it possible for you to go where you want, when you want. It gives you the wherewithal to survive as a free person in a largely unfree world.

HOW MUCH MONEY DO YOU NEED?

How much do you need to be really rich? \$10 million? \$100 million? One hundred million, at 4 percent interest, brings you \$4 million per year. Or about \$2.2 million after tax. But wait, there's inflation, too. If the real loss to inflation is 5 percent, you're losing ground. Even if it is 3 percent, you're still losing ground, after taxes.

So let's explore the numbers. Imagine you have \$100 million and you earn 5 percent per year. After taxes and inflation, you might have \$500,000